

Main

Report Name (Org_Country_Year_Report Type)

Rwanda School Project_Rwanda_2022-23_3-month report

Fellowship Organization

Rwanda School Project (RSP)

Fellowship City

Rwamagana

Fellowship Country

Rwanda

Fellowship Start Date

07/31/2022

Anticipated Fellowship End Date

07/31/2023

What is your fellowship title/role?

Princeton in Africa Fellow

What are your primary responsibilities?

1. Designing and teaching essay writing on computers (focused on using Microsoft Word) during ICT Class
2. Started Read Time book groups, organized a list of novels students can choose from, lead 4 book reading groups and discussed with students
3. College counselor - supporting 40 seniors in their college to attend college, especially US Universities, through this we have taught how to write essays and respond to prompts on computers, giving students ample time and support with both technology and English skills (the language of instruction in Rwanda)
4. SAT Test Prep Tutor - help students with both reading, writing, and math problems for the SAT

I receive adequate direction and support to perform my fellowship responsibilities.

Agree

Did you receive any sort of orientation, handover or onboarding when you started your fellowship?

No

Please describe your orientation/onboarding and note who handled it.
If you did not receive any kind of orientation, what information or guidance were you provided at the start of your fellowship?

It was brief because the job has so much flexibility to do what you want. Moses, my boss, literally asked me "what do you want to do" when I asked what I should start working on.

Describe a representative day at work.

10:30 AM: Arrive at work and begin working on outstanding tasks for the day, currently either editing essays so students have feedback, meeting with a student for help with SAT problems they are struggling with, or preparing for either ICT class or my discussions with students for Read Time
 (MON, THURS ONLY) 11:30 AM - 12:10 PM: Supervising read time groups and conducting discussions
 12:10 PM - 1:00 PM: Lunch
 1:00 PM - 3:10 or 4:30 PM: Continue working on outstanding tasks (same as the morning)
 (THURS ONLY) 3:10-4:30: ICT Class co-teaching
 4:30-6:45: On Tuesdays/Fridays I supervise the seniors in the computer lab who are working on their essays and am there to answer questions they have, on Mondays/Wednesdays/Thursdays I help students with questions on SAT, edit more essays, finish more tasks for the day, or am in the computer lab to help students with questions they have (or if they need 1-on-1 meetings for their essays instead of just written feedback)

On average, how many hours per week do you work?

45

How would you describe your effectiveness in your fellowship post so far?

Very Effective

Please briefly describe 1-2 specific projects that you have undertaken or accomplishments you have made so far.

I have been working closely with the Computer Science teacher to introduce computer skills with essay writing. I co-teach the Senior 4 students on how to use Microsoft Word to write an essay. We are going through every part of writing an essay, from brainstorming to outlining and finally to writing an actual argumentative essay that responds to a prompt. But we also had to start at the very beginning and teach how to type properly.

I have also been working closely with the Senior 6 students to apply to international universities. My co-fellow and I are essentially college counselors for the school and we are helping guide students through every step of the very confusing process, especially for international students.

What is your organization's work culture like?
What is your office environment like? Please comment on the size and structure of the office(s) where you do most of your work.

I work at a school with around 230 students and over 40 staff members, including teachers, administrators, guards, cooks, and boarding staff. I do the majority of my work in the main administration building, in a communal work space shared by the rest of the teachers. I also share a small private office within the admin building with my co-fellow, utilizing it for private meetings, storage, and a quiet work space.

To whom do you report?

I report to the school director.

Have you had an initial check-in with your supervisor to set up a work plan and to set goals for your work during your fellowship year?

Yes

Was this meeting helpful in understanding your role and setting goals for your fellowship year?

Yes

Please explain why you have not met with your supervisor and if you have plans to do so going forward.

Please briefly indicate 3-5 professional goals you have for the rest of your fellowship year. Your professional goals should align with your work plan.

Because we are working at a school, it is the end of November as I am writing this and the students are about to take their term 1 (of 3) final exams. Then they are going home for the holidays. These are goals for over the next two terms, after the Christmas holidays.

1. Create an English (such as TOEFL) and SAT/ACT testing center in Rwamagana, out of the school. Rwamagana is the capital of the Eastern Provinces of Rwanda but all of the current testing centers are in Kigali (the capital), which creates a huge barrier to access for these students to take test that are necessary for studying internationally
2. Re-organize the Read-Time structure of who takes on leading groups and planning a clear schedule that the teachers and staff can follow for the year, this will help ensure the program lives beyond just my Co-Fellow and I.
3. Re-organize the library system because it has been a couple of months and it creates a hindrance to students wanting to access the books. It will also help with the organization of Read-time
4. Involve the younger grades in the requirements and expectations of what it means to apply to college. Especially, starting to work with the current juniors starting next term because we really have to teach these students the basics of how to write essays and if we wait until the fall, it becomes very tight in terms of deadlines.
5. Work with the English teachers and the school director to make sure that students are learning how to write full essays, especially on the computer. Students currently don't have typing skills nor do they do more than write short (usually timed) responses by hand. They aren't taught how to analyze literature and write an analysis essay or an argument essay. I think these skills are so important to have and really want to have this be a change that is made.
6. Increasing familiarity of both staff and students with computers. Potentially looking into how to get a grant for students to have personal computers, but also teaching how to type, how to use Microsoft/Google projects, proper email etiquette, show the teachers Khan Academy and other options for online learning and online teaching tools
7. Create a system where taking standardized tests is more accessible
8. Creating an "English speaking/learning club" because multiple students have requested help with this, so I want to dedicate specific time each week for interested students to meet and improve English through naturally speaking and discussing topics

Do you receive adequate direction/support to perform your fellowship responsibilities?

Please provide more information on your response above.

I had a first meeting with the director when I arrived and then had an additional meeting with the director when my co-fellow arrived. We have had "informal" meetings about some of these goals, but since the term is about to end, and I am wrapping up other things, my co-fellow and I will have another check in at the start of term 2 with the director about a big plan going forward.

How often do you check in with your supervisor?

Irregularly

Have you had an opportunity to travel for work so far?

Yes

Describe this travel opportunity. Include location(s) and a brief description of the purpose of the trip(s).

School field trip to the northern districts of Rwanda supervising a trip to coffee cooperatives

I feel adequately prepared for my position's professional responsibilities.

Strongly Agree

Please briefly explain your response.

I feel adequately prepared. The tasks we have are broad and I wear a lot of different hats. There are no requirements or anything I could have done that would have prepared me better, a lot of it is just being creative and organized! You just have to figure out what you want to do, what the school needs doing, and then think about how you can accomplish what fits between these two requirements.

Life at Fellowship Site

How did you travel to your host country and site? Please be specific

I found my flight by looking at Google Flights, finding the best option in terms of dates/price. I purchased a one-way ticket directly from Ethiopian Airlines. I flew from Denver to Toronto (4:25pm landing at 9:30 pm, operated by Air Canada), then the next day from Toronto to Addis Ababa (11am landing at 7am the following day, operated by Air Ethiopia), then finally from Addis Ababa to Kigali (11:30 am landing at 1:00 pm). And my boss Moses picked me up at their airport. The one-way ticket cost me \$986. I think you could find it cheaper but I flew at the end of July, and booked my ticket 2 weeks before. Also this is when COVID was still causing flights to be crazy/weird pricing.

For additional information, I am flying from Kigali to New York City round trip for about \$1,000 USD leaving in early December and returning in January.

What kind of visa/ permit do you have or applied for?

We entered the country on a tourist visa (30 days and cost 50 USD). Then once here, we applied for a work visa with the help of my supervisor (cost about 150 USD).

How did you obtain (or are obtaining) your visa or permit?

The Rwandan website has all the requirements listed and the school Director helped us apply, but you need the following things (all online because you submit the application online)

Did you apply for and receive your visa / permit before heading to your host country or after arriving?

NO - Tourist visa on arrival at the airport and applied for a work Visa within the 30 days of arriving (before the tourist visa expired)

What costs were associated with obtaining your visa or permit?

Tourist - 50 USD Work - 150,000 Rwandan Francs (about 150 USD)

Did you pay the visa / permit costs or were they covered by your organization?

Covered by my sponsor for my fellowship.

Are you still having challenges obtaining your visa/ permit?

No

If yes, please explain further

g) Do you have any suggestions to help future Fellows navigate the visa / permit application process?

No, it was really easy. If the payment type (like credit card) isn't working, just add money to your Momo Account (associated with your phone SIM card) and pay using that

What vaccinations were you required to obtain prior to your departure? How much did your vaccinations cost? Did you get a yellow fever vaccination?

I didn't get any because I had been to Kenya a couple months earlier, so I was already caught up with everything. I think a Yellow Fever vaccination is required but just check the Government websites and/or go to a travel clinic who will know what is required/recommended for you.

How was your arrival and first week in your host country? Any improvements that could streamline the assimilation process for future Fellows?

Arrival was fine and I was picked up by my Director at the airport. I did have to stay in a hotel room for a couple of days in Rwamagana while they found a security guard for the house.

Is housing provided by and/or paid for by your organization? Please explain.

Housing is provided and paid for by my host organization, using funds from the post sponsor organization Labouisse.

Do you live in a location that is more urban or rural?

Somewhat Rural

Please describe your living environment

I live in a small neighborhood, among other houses and small businesses, and near farm fields.

How do you typically travel between your home and your work? How much does your daily transportation cost and how long is your commute?

It is a 15 minute walk from my house to my work. I pay nothing for transportation to work.

If you live in a more rural area, what are the closest urban areas you can travel to for shopping, airport, larger medical centers, etc.?

The area I live in is pretty rural. There are small shops nearby and a large open air market about a 20 minute walk from my house. However, the closest major grocery stores, general shopping, and an airport are in Kigali, a 1-2 hour drive away, which is pretty accessible via public transportation (1260 RFW, 1.26 dollars on the Bus for about an hour and a half drive and then you can take a Moto (motorcycle) taxi anywhere in the city for less than 2,000 RFW, 2 USD).

How is the weather in your host country? What season are you presently in?

The weather is fairly consistent, with temperatures from 60 to 85 degrees Fahrenheit most days. It is currently the rainy season, so it rains a majority of the days for at least a couple hours. The rain can come suddenly and be very torrential. During the rainy season, the temperature highs are around 76-79 and it occasionally reaches in the low 80s on days it doesn't rain. The rains aren't predictable though, so each season looks different.

What is the appropriate clothing for work and outside of work at your fellowship post and in your community in general?

Appropriate clothing would be anything that is comfortable for the sometimes hot temperature that doesn't reveal too much. The employee handbook said to not show shoulders and thighs. That being said, I have definitely seen other women employees showing their shoulders with wide strap tank shirts or dresses. I have never heard anyone comment on that. Knee length or longer skirts and dresses are nice for women. Though, I never wear leggings and I don't wear dresses that are at/above the knee because I think it just draws too much attention and you get looks. All my dresses hit just below the knee, somewhere at my calves or are (almost) floor length. I would also feel weird wearing just a t-shirt with pants but by no means is professional dress required.

Normal professional clothes are also fine depending on comfort and the temperature. Some people dress really nice, while others opt for casual-professional. Nice sandals are good and you can even buy really cute ones here, and people really pay attention to shoes. There are

also a lot of beautiful sandals you can buy here. A raincoat is a must and maybe a pair of waterproof shoes (or sandals you don't mind getting wet) for when it's rainy.

How have you been spending your free time?

Because we live in a rural area there isn't much to do in Rwamagana. Any activities are generally in Kigali or in other parts of the country. On one hand, Rwanda is small enough that it's really easy and only takes a couple of hours to get to the other side of the country but I also struggle with the lack of things to do here that don't cost money. While it is super fun to go do "touristy" things, such as our trip to see the Gorillas, I have found that Rwanda's tourism industry seems to cater to all-inclusive and expensive activities for foreigners, and so any activities mean that I definitely go WAY over my stipend and have to come from my personal account. I really miss that aspect of the United States where to go out for a hike, even in National Parks or state parks, doesn't require you to pay a lot of money and hire a personal guide. I feel weirdly not independent at times here because of the lack of "things to do." Even when I go into Kigali, it's not a walkable city because it's built across these hills, so I find it hard to find things that aren't just sitting in coffee shops or have to do with spending money.

I also find that our work schedule doesn't really cater to having a lot of time in the evenings to do things, even if there were things to do in Rwamagana. The sun sets at 6:00 PM, so when you leave work around 6:45 pm, it is very dark outside and while Rwanda is much safer than other countries I've been to, and there is definitely a window after the sun sets but before it gets too late, where there are a lot of other people around, which I feel safe go out, I definitely wouldn't without a reason.

I've been able to successfully navigate my personal/social life both back at home and at my fellowship post.

Neutral

Please briefly explain your response below.

I've easily been able to keep in touch with family and friends from home because we have good internet, which isn't too expensive when it is being split with my co-fellow. I talk to my mom everyday (something I've done for years)! I'm also seeing friends over the holidays and don't feel bad not spending the time only with family because we have about a month off (perks of working at a school)!

Like I mentioned above, there isn't a "social scene" to be a part of here in Rwamagana. Especially in the first month I was here alone, I would mostly just have good conversations with people at work and then come home and talk to friends/family on the phone. Outside of the staff at the school, I find it really difficult to speak with locals. My co-fellow and I are some of the only foreigners where we live and locals don't really speak English. Kinyarwanda is a very difficult language to learn as well. I find it hard to talk even with some of the staff and even students at the school because I can tell they don't understand me and I have to really concentrate to understand them, even though classes are taught entirely in English.

We are also far enough away from Kigali that I feel like it's been hard to find a community in Kigali to be a part of. We have made a couple of friends, but not many!

Would you say you live and work in a safe area?

I would say we live and work in a safe area. I've heard of very little crime in the area and know that Rwandans are very serious about keeping peace. Apart from the normal concerns of being a young woman living only with another young woman, and also being some of the only foreigners in town (making it very obvious where we live), I don't worry about it too much. We have a security guard everyday at night as well and a housekeeper during the day.

What precautions do you take to ensure your safety?

I don't go out super late. We have a security guard at night. I don't go walking around with a ton of cash and try to be wary of my surroundings at all times. We lock our doors and have a gate surrounding our house.

What has been your experience with crime so far? (Please note that any security or safety concerns or incidents should be reported directly to PiAf staff per PiAf safety and security protocol.)

I have had no experience with crime so far.

Describe the incidence of crime and the general security situation within your city/town. Could you recommend specific areas future Fellows might consider for safe housing? What about areas that should be avoided?

Again, I have had no experience with crime so far and think that the current housing/area is fine.

Please refer back to the goals you set for yourself before orientation. Are you working towards these goals? Have you met any of them? Changed any of them? Please explain.

I found it hard to have super specific goals because I honestly didn't know what my life or job would look like as a PiAF fellow. I knew that everyday would be a new and unique experience and that there would be challenges that I would have to overcome. I also had a lot of personal goals surrounding working on stress management and trying to live a slower life-style before attending medical school next year and I would definitely say I've gotten practice working on these things!

I really wanted to keep an open mind and just meet opportunities as they came and so far, I would say I have met those goals, especially because I think we have already been able to accomplish so much at work and I think I am making a positive impact in people's lives.

Do you have any frustrations with your living arrangements, your work or your life outside of work?

My frustrations have to do with my working schedule. I don't like starting work at 10:30 am and leaving/getting home around 7pm at night. I am a night-owl and appreciate having time to do what I want in the evenings/nights, which means I often stay up late and wake up late, so it feels like I don't have a ton of time to do things I want without staying up to a ridiculous hour. Sometimes cultural things really grate at me, such as timing (there have been multiple times where I have showed up to things and they haven't begun for HOURS later). And in general, communication can be poor to my co-fellow and I. People won't explain things or won't tell us about things until the last minute or until we hear things through the grape-vine and then ask about them.

Has there been anything that you have needed but have not been able to locate or acquire?

Not really, I struggled a lot at first with how to cook here, especially with no spices, but we have gotten creative and have also gone to different stores in Kigali to find things.

How have you dealt with "culture shock"?

I really talk about my experiences with my friends and family on FaceTime. I also will text about situations I find myself in. Rwandan culture can be very un-spoken at times which I find difficult. One of the first meetings I had was with a former PiAF fellow who is living in Kigali and she brought a friend to meet us for coffee and we talked very openly about their experiences with the "unsaid" cultural norms that they didn't realize as Americans. I found this to be extremely helpful knowledge.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...surprising?

I am the most surprised about how often I have felt really sick here. This is my 3rd extended trip to the East African region and I am no stranger to run-ins with travelers' diarrhea, etc. that foreigners inevitably get, especially while in Africa. HOWEVER, I can honestly say that I was nowhere near as sick in those other places than I am here. I have already taken 2 rounds of antibiotics and probably should have been on more at this point. I feel nauseous way more often than I should and throw-up quite frequently. I'm not really sure what to do about it and am honestly pushing-off figuring it out until I have returned from holidays in the United States. I never expected to be dealing with so many GI issues and it's getting exhausting. I hope I'll have some better solutions by the next fellows report.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...challenging?

The most challenging part, especially at the beginning, was figuring out what to cook and how to navigate the food here. I am not a picky eater in any sense of the word, but I cannot stand most Rwandan food dishes. Even Rwandans will tell you that the food compared to

Tanzania and Kenya is not great. It's all boiled carbohydrates with no seasoning. We have school lunches for us every day but I have to bring my own lunch because I can't eat what is provided (except for on Wednesdays haha), sometimes even the smell of the food makes me not feel well. There are limited options for groceries because we buy everything in an open air market and at first I had no seasonings with me. I also struggled with the stove for a while, but we eventually ended up getting a new one. Even searching for recipes was really difficult because they would always include foods I didn't have access to and food that weren't able to be substituted. There was so much trial and error during my first month here, especially since I was alone and had to figure out literally everything for myself. There were many days at the beginning that I just had fruit or even nothing to eat because the stove wasn't working or I didn't have groceries and had no idea where to go to the market to get things. By the time my co-fellow arrived, I feel like I had really figured out so many things that made her transition so much easier than mine.

What are the top 3 things you miss the most from your home country or the U.S.?

1. Grocery stores nearby with many options
2. How friendly people at home are. While my co-workers are nice, we have invited people over multiple times now and cooked for them. Yet, we have received zero invitations to go to other people's houses. It is just things like this, the little niceties, and chit chat that is very American that I really really miss.
3. General things to do that don't cost money. Even things like going for a walk through the neighborhood. It's not enjoyable to do those things here because we draw so much attention. Even when Rwandans are walking with us, they will always comment on how much attention they are receiving because they are with us. I really miss general outdoor activities and not having to organize and pay for every activity through a guide, it has really discouraged me from seeking out things to do because it just becomes really complicated.

What are the top 3 things about life in your host country that beat out life in your home country or the U.S.?

1. Public transportation here is pretty good and reliable. Rwanda is a small country so I could literally go to the other side of the country on the buses for very cheap and it wouldn't be too hard to navigate
2. I have the time/am "forced" to cook for myself every night. I've gotten really creative and am already thinking about how I can continue this when I move back to the US and have a crazy schedule as a student once again.
3. Maybe the weather? I miss having the seasons but the rainy season is really cool to experience. The rain storms are incredible! Plus we usually have unique clouds in the sky which I like to look at!

How is your stipend being paid?

My stipend is paid monthly in USD to my US account by PiAF

How are you receiving your stipend funds?

ACH

Did you raise funds to cover part of your fellowship expenses?

My family and graduation gifts help me cover additional expenses.

Please list any additional one-time or infrequent expenses not included in your monthly budget below.

Monthly Budget

Rent	Utilities	Furnishings	Phone	Home Security	Internet
\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$5.00	\$0.00	\$35.00
Transportation	Fitness	Entertainment	Groceries	House Cleaning	Eating Out
\$40.00	\$5.00	\$20.00	\$85.00	\$15.00	\$80.00
Medications	Additional Health Insurance	Travel	Laundry	Other	Total Monthly Budget (Minus Entertainment & Travel)
\$3.00	\$0.00	\$80.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	268.00
Specify "Other"					

Final Thoughts

PiAf's orientation was sufficient in preparing me to transition into my fellowship.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response about Orientation.

Yes. No complaints. There isn't much country specific information but I found it really useful to just reach out to previous fellows who are currently living in Rwanda for this information. I don't feel like orientation missed anything.

Is there anything in particular that PiAf could cover at orientation that would have better prepared you for your fellowship post? Please specify.

Nothing I can think of.

As we plan the upcoming PiAf Retreat, we hope to incorporate some Fellow suggestions into our programming. What are some topics or sessions you would like to see at the Retreat? (We appreciate your feedback however, we may not be able to accommodate all suggestions or requests this year.)

Maybe something on tools others might have for creating long-term impact or even how to develop skill set that are useful for the future?